traditions of the "golden" Hindu past; and second, to eliminate all accretions that had become part of the heritage.'[5]

The former project, of digging up ancient glories of the past, is well under way; the latter is proceeding somewhat fitfully and episodically. We will examine both processes below, starting with the battles being fought over history.

One of the amusing, but nonetheless important, sidelights of the development of Hindutva theory has been the controversy about the origins of the Aryans. The Hindutva approach inevitably had implications for the commonly accepted narratives about India, including the idea that the Indo-Aryan people had migrated to northern India from the Central Asian steppes some time around 1500 BCE and authored the foundational texts of Hinduism, the Vedas. Golwalkar believed that was impossible; Hinduism, he was convinced, was an indigenous faith that grew from rather than put down roots in Indian soil, and so the Indo-Aryans could not possibly have come from elsewhere. His and Savarkar's idea of India being the *punyabhumi* of the Hindus required the Aryans to be indigenous to India, in contrast to India's Muslims, whose faith clearly originated in the Arabian peninsula. A veritable cottage industry was born of RSS-inclined historians debunking the Aryan migration theory, insisting that the Aryans, as the founders of Hinduism, belonged all along to India.

Some less-ideological scholars point out that the *Rig Veda* does not speak of any other land but northern India or Aryavarta. In her *Sacred Plants of India*, Dr Nanditha Krishna shows how every plant and animal mentioned in the *Rig Veda* originates from this area. This leads some to the conclusion that the Aryans could not have come from anywhere else. But the same textual and vegetal evidence could also suggest that while the Aryans came from elsewhere, they only composed the Vedas after having created a settled civilisation in the Indo-Gangetic plains, which is why their allusions are all to India.

Unfortunately for the Hindutva ideologues, who seemed to be winning the historical battle, recent genetic research—published in a paper (in a peer-reviewed journal called *BMC Evolutionary Biology*) by Professor Martin P. Richards and fifteen other scientists, titled 'A Genetic